

IS MY ANGER DUE TO UNMET EXPECTATIONS?

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Decrease the frequency of occurrence of angry thoughts, feelings, and behaviors.
2. Think positively and realistically in anger-producing situations.
3. Learn and implement stress management skills, to reduce the level of stress and the irritability that accompanies it.
4. Learn to self-monitor and shift into a thinking and problem-solving mode rather than a reactive mode when anger is triggered.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE PROBLEMS WITH ANGER

- Analyzing Acting-Out Behavior
- Anger as a Drug
- Correcting Distorted Thinking
- Identifying Conflict Themes
- Identifying Relapse Triggers and Cues
- Is My Anger Due to Feeling Threatened?
- Respect or Fear?
- Understanding My Defense Mechanisms
- What Do I Want for My Children?
- What Price Am I Willing to Pay?

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Dangerousness/Lethality
- Family Conflicts
- Oppositional Defiant Behavior
- Parent-Child Relational Problems
- Partner Relational Conflict

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Is My Anger Due to Unmet Expectations?” activity is suited for clients who are capable of introspection and who have the desire to change reactive patterns of anger. It may be useful when clients report feeling unable to control their anger or have patterns of impulsive anger disproportionate to the triggering events or situations. Follow-up can include keeping a journal documenting angry impulses, and the client’s use of this process to identify trigger expectations and manage his/her reactions.

IS MY ANGER DUE TO UNMET EXPECTATIONS?

People in treatment and recovery programs often say that anger always boils down to fear—fear that we will lose something we want to keep, or that we won’t get something we want. Usually, the things that we think we will lose or won’t get aren’t life-and-death matters, yet we often react as if they were. A good example is the road rage we’ve all seen or felt; people have killed each other over who was going to get to the next traffic light 3 seconds sooner. This seems to make no sense.

When we look more closely at what’s going on, we’ll usually find that when possible losses or disappointments trigger intense anger in us, it’s because we expected something different and are disappointed. Sometimes our expectations are based on what we feel is right and fair. These are what some people call the “shoulda-woulda-couldas”; for example, that the person in the next lane should let us merge instead of speeding up to crowd us out, or that people should be honest and considerate with us. Also, sometimes we expect something just because we want it badly and convince ourselves it should happen the way we want it to.

However, our expectations are often not realistic. That’s what leads many old timers in Alcoholics Anonymous and other recovery programs to say, “An expectation is nothing but a premeditated resentment.” By that they mean that when we form expectations, we are often setting ourselves up for disappointment and the anger that follows.

Do you want to avoid getting angry unnecessarily? It’s a good idea to do so; anger interferes with a person’s judgment, makes him/her more likely to act impulsively and do things that damage relationships, undermines recovery, and even weakens the immune system, leaving him/her more vulnerable to cancer, heart disease, stroke, and other life-threatening illnesses.

This exercise will help you get into the habit of avoiding unrealistic expectations, and thereby become able to be calm and at peace more of the time and angry less often.

1. Please think back to the most recent time you got angry. What happened?

2. Was the event that triggered your anger something you felt should not have happened the way it did—in other words, did you have an expectation that something else should have happened?

3. What was your expectation?

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4. Why did you expect what you did—was that what has normally happened before in similar situations?

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5. Often we expect things that experience tells us are unlikely (e.g., expecting someone who has been late many times to show up on time, expecting people to be polite in rush-hour traffic when they are more often aggressive and impatient, expecting to win the lottery when we know the odds are over a million to one against us, expecting that police officer not to pull us over even though we were driving 20 miles per hour over the speed limit). Did you expect something that wasn't likely to happen in the situation you've been writing about? ____ Why was your expectation unrealistic?

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6. How would you have reacted if your expectations had been based on what has happened most often, rather than on what you felt should have happened? Would you have had more peace of mind and less anger?

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7. As you may now be seeing, our expectations are often just plain mistakes in our thinking. If we learn not to make that kind of mistake, we won't be unpleasantly surprised. Acceptance is more comfortable than resentment. Remember, to accept something doesn't mean that we are saying we like it, or that we believe it's right—acceptance just means that we're admitting that things are the way they are, and deciding to deal with reality rather than with our fantasies. If you find yourself facing the same situation again, and base your expectations on reality, what will your reaction be if the same thing happens?

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8. Here are some of the basic, mistaken expectations we form that then create anger. Please give an example of each from your own experience.

a. Expecting someone to behave differently from the way he/she usually behaves (e.g., expecting love and warmth from a person who is normally cold and sarcastic, expecting consideration from someone who is usually thoughtless and selfish).

Example: _____

b. Taking things personally, that is, expecting others to be thinking about us rather than about themselves—expecting to be the center of someone else’s world.

Example: _____

c. Perfectionism, such as expecting ourselves or others to do something perfectly the first time, or the twentieth time, rather than recognizing that we are human and make mistakes.

Example: _____

d. Over-optimism, i.e. expecting everything to go the way we want, though it seldom does.

Example: _____

9. Now that we’re looking at this kind of thinking error, do you see other unreasonable expectations people often form that lead to disappointment and anger?

Please give an example: _____

10. Some other emotions that arise when we form expectations that aren’t met include self-pity, anxiety, and discouragement. In your experience, have anger, self-pity, anxiety, and/or discouragement been triggers for your past addictive behaviors?

11. For this reason, your success in recovery depends on avoiding these emotions as much as possible. The best way to avoid them is to avoid setting yourself up for them. The fewer expectations you have, especially unrealistic ones, the less often you’ll find yourself feeling miserable, and the easier it will be for you to stay in recovery and avoid relapse. If you slip into negative thinking despite your efforts to avoid it—and you will—it helps to stop as soon as you realize that you’re angry about something that happened, and ask yourself, “What was I expecting? Was my expectation realistic?” Your unrealistic expectation may even have been that you wouldn’t make this mistake anymore, so don’t beat yourself up mentally! Please use this space to briefly describe a plan to monitor your thinking and emotions, to avoid unreasonable expectations or detect them as soon as possible, and to regain your serenity.

Be sure to bring this handout back to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.